

Malaria

What is Malaria?

Malaria is a life-threatening disease caused by Plasmodium parasites transmitted through the bite of infected female Anopheles mosquitoes.

Main species: *P. falciparum* (most dangerous, common in India), *P. vivax* (causes relapses), *P. malariae*, *P. ovale*. *P. falciparum* can cause cerebral malaria, a medical emergency.

Symptoms

Classic malaria cycle: chills and shivering, then high fever (up to 41°C), then heavy sweating as fever breaks. This cycle repeats every 48-72 hours depending on parasite species.

Other symptoms: headache, muscle aches, nausea, vomiting, fatigue.

Severe malaria warning signs: altered consciousness, seizures, difficulty breathing, abnormal bleeding, severe anemia, jaundice, very high fever, dark or bloody urine (blackwater fever).

Medicines

P. falciparum treatment: artemisinin-based combination therapy (ACT) such as artemether-lumefantrine or artesunate-amodiaquine.

P. vivax treatment: chloroquine plus primaquine (primaquine eliminates liver stage to prevent relapses). G6PD testing required before primaquine.

Severe malaria: IV artesunate is the drug of choice in hospital settings.

Chemoprophylaxis for travelers: doxycycline, atovaquone-proguanil (Malarone), or mefloquine depending on region.

Emergency Actions

Severe malaria is a medical emergency. Seek hospital care immediately.

Do not delay treatment waiting for test results if severe malaria is clinically suspected.

IV artesunate should be started within 1 hour of diagnosis of severe malaria.

Monitor blood glucose regularly — malaria and its treatment can cause hypoglycemia.

Seizure management: protect airway, give diazepam for convulsions, call 112.

What You Should Do

Sleep under insecticide-treated bed nets (ITNs) especially in endemic areas.

Use mosquito repellents (DEET) and wear protective clothing at dawn and dusk.

Seek diagnosis (rapid test or blood smear) within 24 hours of fever onset in endemic areas.

Complete the full course of antimalarial treatment as prescribed.

Drain standing water around homes. Report malaria cases to local health authorities.